

The Matchmaking Flow

A build guide for first-time production developers · plain language

What this covers: how to build the actual matchmaking experience — meeting potential matches, opening a conversation, and reaching a decision. The AI companion is named **Raya**. Your visual source of truth is the file `sakinah-dev-reference (1).html` — open it in a browser and click each screen. This document gives you the order, the rules, and the "why."

1 The idea, in one minute

This is a Muslim matchmaking experience for people serious about marriage. Unlike swipe apps, it **does not start with a face or a photo**. It works out compatibility from a person's **values and character**, then lets two matched people talk under a safe, structured, family-aware process — and decide for themselves.

By the time a user reaches the matchmaking screens in this guide, they have already (a) **verified their identity** (phone + government ID + a quick selfie/liveness check), and (b) completed a **private character reflection** that produced soft "signals" about who they are. You are building what happens **after** that: the meeting, the conversation, and the decision.

2 Words you must know

Raya	The app's AI companion. She guides the user and offers prompts. She is a helper, never the decision-maker .
Seeker	The person looking for a spouse (the main user).
Wali	A guardian / family member (often a father or brother) who may support and be present in the process. The seeker always makes the final decision .
Nikah	The Islamic marriage contract — i.e. "getting married." Some topics and any closeness are only appropriate after nikah.
Maslak / tradition	The school of Islamic practice a person follows (e.g. Sunni-Hanafi, Shia). The user describes their own ; the app never ranks one above another.
Mutual interest	Both people privately said "yes." Only this opens a conversation. A "no" is always silent.

3 The rules of matchmaking (never break these)

- 1 Character before a face.** No swiping, no photo feed, no public profiles. A photo is exchanged only after **both** people choose to continue, with family aware.

- 2 **A decline is always silent.** Interest is private; a "no" is never shown to the other person as rejection.
- 3 **Only a mutual "yes" opens a conversation.** And the first message is always guided by Raya — never a blank chat box.
- 4 **Structure, not casual chat.** Conversations move topic-by-topic, with a wali inevitable, and no dating-style free-for-all.
- 5 **Closeness/intimacy is an after-nikah topic only.** It must never appear as a chat topic before marriage.
- 6 **People decide — never the AI.** Raya may help a person think; she must never recommend or decide an outcome.
- 7 **Honesty over a bad match.** If there aren't enough good matches, say so. Never fake a full pool.
"We'd rather show you no one than the wrong one."

4 The matchmaking flow at a glance

Matchmaking is five steps. Build them in this order.

Step 1 THE POOL	→	Step 2 A CANDIDATE	→	Step 3 MATCH FLOW	→	Step 4 CONVERSATION	→	Step 5 THE DECISION
A small, curated few (3-5) – not a feed.		One person shown as character, never a face.		Private interest → mutual yes opens a chat.		8 topics that unlock one by one, wali aware, Raya moderates.		Proceed, pause, or close – each with dignity.

5 Build the five steps

STEP 1 The considered few (the pool)

Goal: Show a small, curated handful of compatible people — never an endless feed.

MUST DO

- Show about **3–5 PEOPLE** to consider, chosen from values, conduct, and shared tradition.
- When the user passes on one, bring the next after a calm beat.
- **CAP ACTIVE CONVERSATIONS AT ONE OR TWO.**
- If the pool is thin, show an honest empty state — don't pad it.

MUST NEVER DO

- No infinite feed, no swipe gesture, no "see who liked you."
- Don't fake abundance. Don't reward binge-browsing.

Save: the current considered set; the count of active conversations.

Done when: the user has a small, honest, high-quality set to reflect on.

STEP 2 A resonance (one candidate)

Goal: Show one potential match as a **character portrait**, never a face.

MUST DO

- Lead with shared values, the honest shared edge (e.g. "both still learning to let people in"), and the tradition match.
- **NO PHOTO UNTIL MUTUAL INTEREST**
— and even then, with family aware.
- A "pass" is silent and dignified.

MUST NEVER DO

- No photo-first, no public profile, no swipe.
- Never frame a pass as a rejection of the other person.

Save: interest expressed (privately) or a silent pass.

Done when: the user can express interest based on character alone.

STEP 3 Match flow (a structured opening)

Goal: Turn mutual interest into a **structured** opening — not a free chat request.

MUST DO

- Six gated steps: both profiles complete → compatibility identified → **MUTUAL INTEREST REQUIRED**
→ structured opening (Raya frames the first message) → wali/family invitable → supervised depth.
- **INTEREST STAYS PRIVATE; ONLY A MUTUAL "YES" OPENS A CONVERSATION.**

MUST NEVER DO

- No open or blank chat box. No casual / dating-style interaction. No uncontrolled escalation.
- **NEVER TELL SOMEONE THEY WERE DECLINED**
— a decline is silent.

Save: which of the 6 steps the pair is on; wali-invitation state.

Done when: a conversation only opens after a private, mutual yes, with a guided first step.

STEP 4 Communication (topic by topic, with family)

Goal: Let two people get to know each other safely and seriously, with structure.

MUST DO

- **EIGHT PRE-NIKAH TOPICS THAT UNLOCK ONE AT A TIME**
as trust grows: Parents & Family, Work, Friends, Habits, Self-image, Responsibility, Expectations, Finances.
- A
WALI CAN BE PRESENT.
Use gentle ~24-hour response windows (no late-night pressure).
- Keep everything
IN-APP AND WATERMARKED.
Raya offers prompts and moderates tone.
- A scholar-counsellor is one tap away for escalation.

MUST NEVER DO

- No media/photos before the gated stage. No leaking phone numbers or contact info.
- No read-receipt pressure games.
- **INTIMACY/CLOSENESS NEVER OPENS BEFORE NIKAH**
— it's the locked, after-nikah topic.
- **THE AI NEVER DECIDES THE OUTCOME.**

Save: which topics are unlocked; wali-present state; message history (in-app, watermarked).

Done when: the pair can explore real topics in order, safely, with family aware.

STEP 5 The decision

Goal: Let the **people** decide — proceed, pause, or close — with dignity.

MUST DO

- **PROCEED**
— Raya helps coordinate a family-present next step toward nikah.
- **PAUSE**
— no clock, no guilt; time for reflection / istikhara.
- **CLOSE**
— a clean, respectful end: a dua, no blame.

MUST NEVER DO

- The AI must **NOT** recommend an outcome. No pressure to proceed.
- No "rejected" framing and no blame notification on a close.

Save: the chosen outcome.

Done when: a human decision is made and honoured, gently, whichever way it goes.

6 Raya (the AI) — what she may and may not do

RAYA MAY

- Guide each step and explain the "why."
- Frame questions and offer gentle conversation prompts.
- Offer soft compatibility insights and moderate the tone of a conversation.
- Escalate to a human scholar-counsellor when needed.

RAYA MUST NOT

- Manipulate emotions or push attachment.
- Decide or recommend a marriage outcome.
- Replace human judgment, or build addictive engagement loops.

When in doubt: Raya helps the human think. The human — with their family and their Lord — decides.

7 Safety must-haves (women-first) — not optional

Matchmaking cannot go live until every box below is true. These protect against an **insider** — a verified user who might misuse the platform.

- ☐ Photos stay hidden until **both** people choose; then they are **watermarked with the viewer's own ID** burned in, so any leak traces back to the leaker.
- ☐ **No public profiles and no search** — nothing exists for a bad actor to browse or scrape.

- A **banned identity cannot re-register** (hard identity verification).
- **Report → human review → permanent ban** works end to end.
- Conversations are **in-app and watermarked**; no contact-info leakage.
- A wali can be present where chosen; consent always stays with the seeker.

8 Data & flags cheat sheet

FLAG / DATA	SET AT	WHAT IT MEANS
<code>active_conversations</code> (cap 1–2)	Step 1 · Pool	Stops binge behaviour; limits how many chats run at once.
Interest / silent pass	Step 2 · Candidate	Interest is private; a pass is never shown to the other person.
<code>matchflow_step</code> (1–6)	Step 3 · Match flow	Which of the six gated steps the pair is on.
<code>mutual_yes</code>	Step 3 · Match flow	Required before any conversation opens.
<code>unlocked_topics</code> (of 8)	Step 4 · Communication	Topics open one at a time; intimacy stays locked until after nikah.
<code>wali_present</code>	Step 4 · Communication	Whether a guardian is in the conversation.
Decision outcome	Step 5 · Decision	Proceed / pause / close — set by the human, never the AI.

9 Definition of Done

A step is finished only when **all** of these are true:

- It **looks and behaves like the HTML reference** for that screen.
- Every "Must do" works, and every "Must never do" is genuinely impossible in the build — not just hidden.
- It respects all seven matchmaking rules (Section 3).
- The data it saves matches the cheat sheet (Section 8) and stores the minimum needed.
- Raya, where present, stays inside her allowed role (Section 6).
- It works gently for a nervous first-time user: calm tone, pause-and-return, no pressure.

10 Common mistakes to avoid

- ✗ Adding any swipe, feed, photo-first, or "who liked you" element. Character comes before a face — always.
- ✗ Showing a real rejection. A decline is always silent.
- ✗ Opening a free/blank chat box instead of a Raya-guided, topic-by-topic conversation.
- ✗ Showing an intimacy/closeness topic before nikah. It's locked until after marriage.
- ✗ Letting the AI decide or recommend an outcome. People decide.
- ✗ Faking a full pool when there aren't enough good matches. Be honest.
- ✗ Letting any photo or contact info leave the app un-watermarked.

Keep this guide open beside the HTML reference while you build. The HTML shows the "how"; this guide holds the "rules and why." If the two ever seem to disagree, ask a senior before shipping.